

Documentary research and the MA thesis

Université de Mostaganem

Cours TIC RDOC-M2-EN

Plan du chapitre 01

1. Documentary research epistemology
2. Source types in language didactics
3. Thesis structure
4. Module objectives
5. 10-session series overview
6. Teaching methodology
7. Digital tools and ethics
8. Conclusion

1. Introduction (10 min)

In MA Year 2 DLE (Didactics of Foreign Languages), the thesis is the first experience of argued research in language didactics. Documentary research is not a preliminary step : it structures the entire work from problem formulation to discussion of results.

Documentary research covers all methodological steps to identify, select, evaluate, read actively and synthesise academic sources in support of a didactic research question.

This 10-session module (10 × 1h30) provides a reproducible documentary protocol aligned with international standards (APA 7, academic integrity, GDPR).

- Thesis = argued research on a precise didactic problem
- Bibliographic corpus = foundation of the state of the art
- 90-minute session : theory, examples, Tutorial 01 preparation

2. Epistemology of the MA thesis (15 min)

Language didactics thesis belongs to social sciences applied to language teaching/learning. It links theoretical framework, empirical approach and critical discussion confronting field data and literature.

Research type	Objective	MA DLE example
Documentary research	State of the art	Literature review on L2 motivation
Action research	Transform practice	Flipped classroom protocol in EFL
Case study	Analyse context	Moodle use in a pilot school
Survey / experiment	Test hypothesis	Impact of online quizzes on vocabulary

3. Source types in language didactics (15 min)

3.1 Primary academic sources

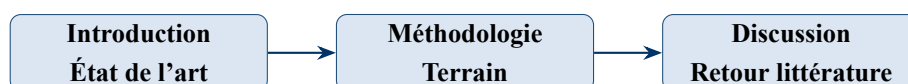
- ▶ Peer-reviewed journals : System, TESOL Quarterly, Language Learning & Technology
- ▶ Reference books : Ellis, Harmer, Kumaravadivelu
- ▶ Theses : HAL, university repositories

3.2 Institutional sources and corpora

- ▶ British Council, Council of Europe (CEFR) reports
- ▶ Corpora : BNC, TED Open Corpus
- ▶ Teaching resources : distinct from central research sources

4. Thesis structure (12 min)

- ▶ Introduction : context, partial state of art, research question
- ▶ Methodology : design, population, tools, ethics
- ▶ Discussion : field results vs literature



Articulation du mémoire M2 DLE

FIG. 1 : Enchaînement logique introduction – méthodologie – discussion.

5. Module objectives and 10-session series (18 min)

Session	Theme	Key skill
01	Thesis & DR	Epistemological frame
02	Research question	Investigable problem
03	Keywords	Boolean queries
04	Databases	ERIC, JSTOR, Scholar
05	Specialised portals	Documentary watch
06	CRAP	Critical evaluation
07	Zotero	Bibliographic management
08	APA 7 / MLA 9	Rigorous citation
09	Literature review	Argumentative synthesis
10	Integrity & protocol	Final deliverable



FIG. 2 : Chaîne de la recherche documentaire appliquée au mémoire.

6. Teaching methodology and assessment (10 min)

- ▶ Interactive lecture (1h30) + applied tutorial (1h30) per session
- ▶ Lab work : online databases, Zotero
- ▶ Assessment : protocol 50%, source analysis 30%, participation 20%

7. Digital tools and ethics (10 min)

Digital tools accelerate collection but do not replace critical evaluation. Academic ethics requires citing all borrowed ideas and declaring AI use per institutional charter.

8. Synthesis and Tutorial 01 preparation (10 min)

- ▶ Tutorial 01 : definition, source typology, thesis diagram, goals, timeline
- ▶ Create folder MA_Thesis_DLE this week

Key takeaway : Documentary research is the epistemological foundation of the MA DLE thesis.

9. Commented case study (12 min)

9.1 Example : thesis on L2 lexical motivation

Context : an MA DLE student studies the impact of Moodle quizzes on lexical motivation in Year 10 secondary school. Documentary research starts with an investigable question, not random article collection.

Step 1 — Field mapping : consult *System*, ERIC (vocabulary learning, Moodle, secondary EFL), and Cairn (motivation, lexicon, digital). Target : 15 pre-selected references in two weeks.

Step 2 — Active reading : for each central article, note in Zotero : population, method, results, limits, link to local context. One sheet per central source.

Step 3 — Synthesis : identify convergences (moderate positive effect of frequent quizzes on engagement) and gaps (few North African secondary-school studies). The gap justifies the thesis.

9.2 Week 1 checklist

1. Folder MA_Thesis_DLE created (cloud + local backup).
2. Provisional question written in one sentence.
3. 5 EN and 5 FR keywords tested on ERIC and Scholar.
4. Zotero account with browser connector installed.
5. 3 articles read in full (not abstract only).

9.3 Transferable skills

- ▶ **Autonomy** : query multiple databases independently.
- ▶ **Critical thinking** : evaluate before downloading ; always read the abstract.
- ▶ **Rigour** : trace every reference (DOI, database, access date).
- ▶ **Communication** : present protocol clearly to thesis supervisor.

Assessment reminder : final protocol (session 10) counts for 50% of the module grade.

10. Session 01 — Extended resources (5 min)

- ▶ ERIC : <https://eric.ed.gov> — education and applied linguistics.
- ▶ Google Scholar alerts : weekly monitoring of main Boolean query.
- ▶ Zotero quick start : https://www.zotero.org/support/quick_start_guide.
- ▶ APA 7 overview : Purdue OWL — <https://owl.purdue.edu>.

Next session : research question and problem statement (Session 02).

11. References

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